wrote a personal letter to Ratan, repenting and regretting his attacks on the chairman. He wrote, ‘I was not only unkind but completely wrong in my assessment of you … I wonder if you will ever be able to forgive me but I do offer you an unconditional apology. Should you be able to forgive me, I shall feel happy.’

Ratan, on his part, held no rancour towards Mody. He would meet Mody at his residence and spent time with him when there was an opportunity. Even a few months before Mody passed away in 2014, Ratan visited his home and had dinner with him, and they spent time discussing issues of common interest.

Darbari Seth

When the TISCO board removed Russi Mody as chairman and appointed Ratan in his stead, it brought the curtain down on a difficult chapter in the history of the Tata Group. It was the beginning of the end of the era of individuals running Tata companies without the group spirit and a significant step towards the professionalization of the Tata enterprises.

Darbari Seth, the legendary chief managing director of Tata Chemicals, would be the next to go. Born in 1920, Seth, a chemical engineer from the University of Cincinnati, was hand-picked by JRD for Tata Chemicals. He contributed immensely to the group and emerged as a builder of institutions who, with his vision and drive, earned the sobriquet of the ‘man with the Midas touch’. Seth’s pioneering spirit, entrepreneurship and inventiveness brought him closer to JRD, whom he advised on important matters.

At one point, Seth was the director of over twenty companies and chairman of some fourteen others. But his vision and spirit were not confined to the corporate sector. In 1974, he established the Tata Energy Research Institute (TERI; now The Energy and Resources Institute). In view of his remarkable success, he was described as a man with ‘limitless vision’. JRD had once paid him an unusual encomium, saying: ‘Darbari Seth is undoubtedly the leading entrepreneur of the Tata group.’ With so many accomplishments under his belt and his proximity to JRD, Seth was perceived to be a strong contender to succeed him.

But when Ratan was appointed as chairman, Seth was more worried about preserving his style of functioning. His reaction was muted, and he preferred to ignore Ratan. When asked about the choice of Ratan as the